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Dear Editors,

Please consider our manuscript entitled "Habitat coupling by small fish across lake–creek habitats: a missing link in freshwater food webs?" for publication as a Letter in *Ecology Letters*.

Habitat coupling is a central concept in food web ecology, yet it is often inferred from the movements and resource use of large-bodied consumers. In this manuscript, we show that small-bodied fishes can also act as important habitat couplers, linking adjacent freshwater lake and creek habitats through both resource assimilation and movement behaviour. Using a multi-method field approach including stable isotope analysis, acoustic telemetry, and seasonal biomass flux estimates, we demonstrate that these fishes integrate carbon from both habitats, move frequently across the lake–creek boundary, and contribute to seasonal exchange of biomass between habitats.

Our results reveal that coupling is not constant through time, but instead varies across seasons, with the strongest lake–creek habitat coupling occurring in spring and fall and the weakest in summer. This seasonal pattern suggests that small-bodied consumers may play an underappreciated role in maintaining energy flows across spatially distinct habitats, particularly when environmental conditions or predation risk vary through time. In doing so, our study advances understanding of how spatially structured food webs are connected and highlights the need to look beyond large predators when evaluating habitat coupling and the processes that promote resilience in freshwater systems.

We believe this manuscript will be of broad interest to *Ecology Letters* readers because it addresses a general ecological question with clear implications for food web theory and spatial ecology. It also speaks to how movement, resource use, and biomass exchange jointly shape the functioning of connected ecosystems and promises to excite further research on habitat coupling across taxa and temporal scales. Further, our findings have important implications for managing habitat connectivity and protecting the ecological processes that maintain freshwater biodiversity in the face of ongoing global change.

We have taken care to ensure the manuscript is focused, original, and appropriate for the scope and format of a Letter. Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

C Ward

Dr. Charlotte A. Ward
on behalf of all co-authors